



LEISURE

in 2013. It took four years and 150 truckloads of stone masonry to fix. "It's really mind-boggling figures," says Ratish Nanda, CEO of the Trust and a conservation architect. "When we started the effort, you won't believe it, we were buying water [for the lime-stone-based conservation work]. For a project that spans 106 acres and 100 monuments, it was unsustainable in more ways than one."

The stepwells can now collect 21 million litres of water annually, which will irrigate the surrounding greens. "From our perspective," says Nanda, "it has been critical to show how conservation can fulfil other government objectives, in this case making the site net zero for water requirements."

Besides stepwells, the complex is a smorgasbord of architectural delights, including a Persian-style hamam, delicate minarets, gardens, pavilions and, above all, spectacular globular domes. Even during phase-wise restoration, most of the park was open to the public.

But there were several challenges before the park could be nursed back to glory—apart from missing parts, accreted paint layers and damage to the facades, there were also court petitions, contesting the restoration itself. "No challenge or frustration is an issue; it's such an incredible site," says Nanda. "Every day has been a story of discovery. We found glazed tiles, garden enclosure walls, aqueducts. Through the project, we have been able to enhance an understanding of the Qutb Shahis."

Kumar adds that the location is already being used as a revitalised cultural space—a newly-constructed amphitheatre nearby hosted music festivals last year with the tombs in the background. "It's not just restoring the structure. We should have economic integration and economic rejuvenation of people and stakeholders around these structures," he says. Future plans include building a museum. The entire complex is likely to take another three years to complete. "Once it's done," says Nanda. "I think it will rank among the greatest sites in the Indian subcontinent." ■

Bhavya Dore

Among the project's major achievements so far has been reviving the six surviving baolis (left)



says Kumar. "That was the basic idea to take up the restoration of the tombs. We thought it should be a part of the overall effort to get Hyderabad the heritage tag."

The complex is on the tentative world heritage list. Conservation work is still ongoing at the site, but among the project's major achievements so far has been reviving the six surviving *baolis*. Two had been almost entirely lost and filled in, another two were visible, but cracked. One even collapsed shortly after the MoU was signed

HERITAGE

MADE TO LAST

Other ongoing restoration works



DELHI

Phase one of work has been completed at Delhi's iconic Chandni Chowk market with an initial focus on decongesting and landscaping the bustling area. Parts have been retiled, pedestrian pathways widened and overhead wires removed. The second phase will focus on restoring building facades, structural repairs, signage and illumination.



MUMBAI

Parts of the 130-year-old colonial-era Acworth Hospital will be restored at a cost of Rs 4 crore, the city civic body recently announced. The Grade-II heritage structure was originally built to treat leprosy patients in Wadala, once on the city's outskirts. The premises include a chapel, mosque and temple, the main focus of the revival works.

CHENNAI

The municipal corporation is planning to resume work on the Victoria Hall at an estimated Rs 25-crore plus. The Indo-Saracenic-styled town hall, named in honour of Queen Victoria, was the site of public meetings, shows and other social events.

